7 THE INADEQUACY OF GRAMMAR

Gone is the whiteness
of snow—
green returns
in the grass of the fields,
in the canopies of trees,
and the airy grace of spring
is with us again.
Thus time revolves,
the passing hour that steals
the light
brings a message:
immortality, for us, is impossible.
Warm winds will be followed by cold. (IV, 7)

Usually, we call “real” the things that exist *now*, in the present. Not those which existed once, or may do so in the future. We say that things in the past or the future “were” real or “will be” real, but we do not say they “are” real.

Philosophers call “presentism” the idea that only the present is real, that the past and the future are not—and that *reality* evolves from one present to another, successive one.

This way of thinking no longer works, however, if the “present” is not defined globally, if it is defined only in our vicinity, in an approximate way. If the present that is far away from here is not defined, what “is real” in the universe?

Diagrams such as the ones that we have seen in previous chapters depict *an entire evolution* of spacetime with a single image: they do not represent a single time but all times together: